Political Unification Of India

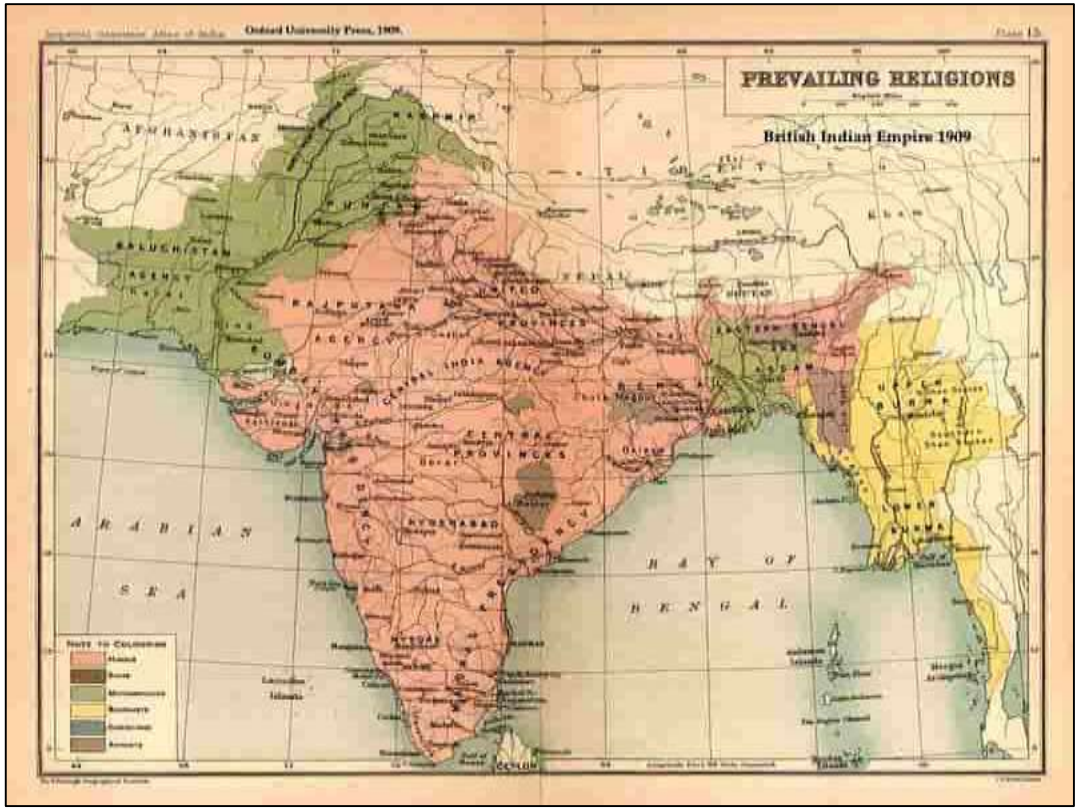
- Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, the indomitable man who integrated 562 princely states with the Union of India and prevented the Balkanization of the newly independent country, owes an incalculable debt of gratitude to the vision, tact, diplomacy, and pragmatic approach of today’s India.
- India finally gained its hard-won independence in 1947, but it came with a slew of problems, including partition, communal riots, and a refugee crisis.
- It’s easy to see why India's new government found the integration of more than 500 princely states a difficult nut to crack, given the country's crippling resource constraints, fledgling institutions, and ill-equipped colonial machinery.
- Patel, India’s first deputy prime minister and home affairs minister, would not only handle these issues deftly and dexterously but would go on to be known as the “Architect of Modern India.”

- Vallabhbhai Patel had already established himself as one of the most popular leaders of the freedom struggle after making his mark in the Kheda and Bardoli satyagrahas (during which he earned the title of ‘Sardar’).
- By 1946, he had already established himself as one of the most popular leaders of the freedom struggle. He was a man of few words, stoic and simple in his habits, but when he did speak, people listened. As India’s first deputy prime minister and home minister, he was tasked with the difficult task of integrating the princely states. He got to work with the speed of a military commander and the dexterity of a natural diplomat, ably assisted by V.P. Menon (then Lord Mountbatten's Constitutional Adviser and later the Secretary of the Ministry of the States).
- The princely states accounted for 48 percent of pre-independence India’s land area and 28 percent of its population. Despite the fact that these kingdoms were not legally part of British India, they were completely subordinate to the British Crown in reality.

- The Indian Independence Act of 1947 (based on the Mountbatten Plan) allowed the British Crown's paramountcy over Indian states to lapse. It also gave each of these rulers the option of joining the newly formed dominions of India or Pakistan or remaining as a sovereign state.
- Recognizing the urgency of gaining the acceptance of these 500-plus chiefdoms before India’s Independence Day, Patel and Menon began employing all of their tricks, including force and friendly advice, to achieve their integration with the Indian dominion. However, the procedure was far from straightforward.
- Many of the rulers, who had been mollycoddled and exploited by the British for decades, saw the British departure as the ideal time to declare autonomy and declare their independent statehood on the world map. Patel (who laid out the framework) and Menon (who laid the actual groundwork) persisted.

Integration of princely state:

- He tried everything he could to persuade the princes to join India, from invoking their patriotism to warning them about the possibility of anarchy if they refused.
- He also proposed the concept of "privy purses", which would be a payment made to royal families in exchange for their consent to merge with India.
- Patel hosted a series of lunch parties in the spring of 1947, urging his princely guests to assist the Congress in drafting a new Indian constitution.
- Patel's tireless efforts paid off when the majority of rulers agreed to dissolve their states, handing over control of thousands of villages, jagirs, palaces, institutes, cash balances in the billions of rupees, and a 12,000-mile railway system to the Indian government without receiving any compensation.



- Except for a few princely states that resisted, the process of princely state integration was nearly complete by August 15, 1947. Some simply waited until the last possible moment to sign the Instrument of Accession, such as Piploda, a small state in central India that did not join India until March 1948.
- However, the most serious issues arose with Jodhpur, which attempted to negotiate better deals with Pakistan, Junagadh, which did accede to Pakistan, and Hyderabad and Kashmir, both of which declared their intention to remain independent.

Integration of Jodhpur:

- With the transfer of power looming on the horizon, Maharaja Hanvant Singh ascended the throne of Jodhpur in June 1947 and began to waver on his predecessor's commitment to join India. He was young and inexperienced, but he believed that because his state was adjacent to Pakistan, he could get a better "deal."
- As a result, Hanvant Singh began talks with Mohammed Ali Jinnah, who is said to have given the Maharaja a signed blank sheet of paper on which to write down all of his demands. The princely state was allowed to accede to Pakistan on any terms it wanted, from free access to the Karachi port to arms manufacturing and importing.
- Seeing the dangers of the border state joining Pakistan, Patel met with Hanvant Singh right away and assured him that importing arms would be permitted, that Jodhpur would be connected to Kathiawar by rail, and that India would provide grain during famines.
- Following the carrots, the stick came in the form of more serious warnings: it was pointed out that the accession of a predominantly Hindu state to Pakistan would violate the two-nation theory's basic tenet and would almost certainly result in communal violence in the country. As a result, Jinnah's blank check was quickly revoked, and Jodhpur became part of India.

Annexation of Junagadh:

- Junagarh, a princely state on Gujarat's southwestern border, also refused to join the Indian union by August 15, 1947. It was the most important of the Kathiawar states, with a large Hindu population, and was ruled by Muhammad Mahabat Khanji III, the Nawab.
- Nawab Mahabat Khanji chose to join Pakistan on September 15, 1947, despite Mountbatten's objections, claiming that Junagadh was connected to Pakistan by sea. The rulers of two states under Junagadh's suzerainty — Mangrol and Babariawad — retaliated by declaring independence from Junagadh and acceding to India.
- The Nawab of Junagadh retaliated by militarily occupying the two states. Other neighbouring states retaliated angrily, sending troops to the Junagadh border and appealing to the Indian government for help.
- India believed that allowing Junagadh to join Pakistan would exacerbate communal tensions in Gujarat, so it refused to accept the Nawab's choice of accession. The government cited the state's 80 percent Hindu population as justification for a plebiscite on the issue of accession.

- India cut off fuel and coal supplies to Junagadh, severed air and postal links, sent troops to the border, and occupied the acceded-to-India principalities of Mangrol and Babariawad. Pakistan agreed to talk about a plebiscite in exchange for the withdrawal of Indian troops, which India refused.
- Following clashes with Indian troops on October 26, the Nawab and his family fled to Pakistan. The Nawab had emptied the state treasury of cash and securities before leaving. Junagadh's court, facing collapse, invited the Government of India to take over the state's administration on November 7, 1947.
- Sir Shah Nawaz Bhutto, the Dewan of Junagadh and father of the more famous Zulfiqar Ali Bhutto decided to seek intervention from the Indian government. The Indian government accepted the Dewan's invitation to intervene. In February 1948, a plebiscite was held, with almost unanimous support for India's accession. Junagadh was a part of the Indian state of Saurashtra until November 1, 1956, when it was absorbed into the state of Bombay.

Annexation of Kashmir:

- In 1960, the state of Bombay was divided into the linguistic states of Maharashtra and Gujarat, which included Junagadh. Since then, Junagadh has been a part of Gujarat.
- Kashmir was a princely state ruled by a Hindu king over a majority Muslim population that had resisted joining either of the two dominions. This strategically located kingdom's case was not only unique but also one of the most difficult, as it had significant international borders.
- Maharaja Hari Singh, the ruler of Kashmir, had proposed a cease-fire agreement to both India and Pakistan, pending a final decision on the state's accession. Pakistan signed the cease-fire agreement, but an army of soldiers and Pakistani lashkars (armed tribesmen) carrying weapons invaded Kashmir from the north.
- Thousands of tribal Pathan swept into Kashmir in the early hours of October 24, 1947. The Maharaja of Jammu and Kashmir requested assistance from India. He sent Sheikh Abdullah, his representative, to Delhi to seek India's assistance. Maharaja Hari Singh fled Srinagar and arrived in Jammu on October 26, 1947, where he signed the J&K state’s “Instrument of Accession.”
- Indian jurisdiction would extend to external affairs, communications, and defence, according to the terms of the document. Following the signing of the document, Indian troops were airlifted into Kashmir and fought alongside the Kashmiris.

- Maharaja Hari Singh announced the formation of an interim popular government on the 5th of March, 1948, with Sheikh Mohammed Abdullah as Prime Minister. The state constituent assembly was elected in 1951.
- On October 31, 1951, it convened for the first time in Srinagar.
- The Delhi Agreement, signed in 1952 by the Prime Ministers of India and Jammu & Kashmir, granted the state special status within the Indian Constitutional framework. The constituent assembly of J&K ratified the state's accession to the Union of India on February 6, 1954. Following that, the President issued a constitutional order under Article 370 of the Constitution, which extended the Union Constitution to the state, with some exceptions and modifications.
- Jammu & Kashmir is and will remain an integral part of India, according to Section 3 of the J&K constitution. The Constitution (Application to Jammu and Kashmir) Order, 2019 was promulgated by the President of India on August 5, 2019.
- The order effectively repeals the special status granted to Jammu and Kashmir under Article 370, which stated that provisions of the Constitution that applied to other states did not apply to Jammu and Kashmir (J&K).

Annexation of Hyderabad

- The ruling class in Hyderabad (India's largest and wealthiest princely state) had flatly refused to join the Indian empire. Patel and other mediators' requests and threats failed to sway the cunning Nizam, who continued to expand his army by importing weapons from Europe.
- When armed fanatics known as Razakars unleashed violence against Hyderabad's Hindu residents, things took a turn for the worse. Patel acted once more. In what became known as 'Operation Polo,' Indian forces marched into Hyderabad on September 17, 1948.
- The Nizam was forced to surrender and merge his kingdom with the Indian Union after a four-day armed encounter, 13 months after India gained independence. Later, as a reward for his submission, the Nizam was appointed governor of the state of Hyderabad.

Integration of Indian STATE: TRAVANCORE

- Travancore, a maritime state in southern India, was strategically located for maritime trade and had abundant human and mineral resources. It was one of the first princely states to reject Indian union membership and cast doubt on the Congress' leadership of the country.
- By 1946, Sir C.P. Ramamswamy Aiyar, the Dewan of Travancore, had declared his intention of forming an independent state of Travancore that would be willing to sign a treaty with the Indian Union.
- Sir C.P. Aiyar is also said to have had secret ties with the British government, which supported an independent Travancore in the hope of gaining exclusive access to a mineral called monazite, which was abundant in the area and would give Britain an advantage in the nuclear arms race. He remained in his position until July 1947.
- After surviving an assassination attempt by a member of the Kerala Socialist Party, he changed his mind. Travancore became a part of India on July 30, 1947.

Integration of Indian STATE: Bhopal

- Hamidullah Khan, a Muslim Nawab, ruled over a majority Hindu population. He was a close ally of the Muslim League and a vocal opponent of the Congress' rule. He'd made it clear to Mountbatten that he wanted independence.
- However, the latter replied that “no ruler could flee the dominion closest to him.” The Prince became aware of the large number of princes who had acceded to India by July 1947 and decided to join them.

Integration of Indian STATE: Lakshadweep

- While Patel’s role in bringing these royal territories into the Indian union is well-known, few people are aware that he also integrated Lakshadweep at a later date, ensuring that the beautiful coral atolls remained part of India.
- Pakistan began eyeing the strategically located and almost “out-of-sight” island archipelago that had been barely informed of the Independence shortly after August 15, 1947.
- The Pakistani Navy’s attempt to seize Lakshadweep was thwarted when Patel quickly dispatched Indian naval ships to defend the island. As a result, the ever-pragmatic Patel and his brilliant secretary succeeded in unifying the princely states into the Indian union.